



Milena Vásquez-Amézquita

ASSOCIATE PROFESSOR

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📁 Milena-Vasquez-Amezquita | 🏠 grupo-codec.netlify.app/author/milena-vasquez-amezquita/

I am a researcher primarily interested in the neurocognitive bases of human affect and sexuality.

About me

Psychologist, MSc in Basic and Applied Neurosciences, and PhD in Neurosciences. I am a researcher in cognitive neuroscience applied to human sexual behavior. My research integrates cognitive neuroscience, evolutionary psychology, and public health to understand how the brain processes sexually relevant information and how these mechanisms shape sexual attraction, mate preferences, sexual response, and sexual behavior. Using experimental methods—particularly eye tracking—I investigate both normative and atypical sexual interests, with the goal of advancing basic science and informing evidence-based strategies for the prevention of child sexual abuse and exploitation.

I am an Associate Professor at the [Faculty of Psychology](#) at [Universidad El Bosque](#) and an active associate researcher within the [CODEC: Cognitive and Behavioural Sciences](#) Research Group (classified **A1** by MinCiencias). I lead the [SexCog: Sexuality and Affectivity from a Neurocognitive Perspective](#) research hotbed and have led and co-led internally and externally funded research projects using experimental approaches in cognitive neuroscience. I completed a postdoctoral fellowship at [Universidad de la Costa](#), funded by [MinCiencias](#).

Over the past 15 years, I have combined research and university teaching, contributing to undergraduate and graduate education in the neurobiological and cognitive bases of human behavior while supervising undergraduate, master's, and doctoral research projects.



Skills

Programming	R (Basic, data analysis and graph generation)
Quantitative Research	Observational-correlational studies, Simple and Mixed general linear models
Recording techniques	Eye tracking (mainly), other basic HRV, EEG
Software	RStudio, Tobii Pro Lab, Qualtrics, Psychomorph, WebmorphR, Mendeley and Zotero
Languages	English/Spanish (native)

Education

Universidad de Valencia	Valencia, España
PHD - NEUROSCIENCES	2018
Universidad de Valencia	Valencia, España
MASTER'S DEGREE IN BASIC AND APPLIED NEUROSCIENCES	2012
Universidad Católica de Colombia	Bogotá, Colombia
PSYCHOLOGY	2007

Research Experience

Universidad El Bosque	Bogotá, Colombia
ASSOCIATE PROFESSOR	Jan. 2020 - Present
Universidad de la Costa	Barranquilla, Colombia
VISITING PROFESSOR	Dec.2023 - Present
Universidad Internacional de Valencia	Valencia, España
COLLABORATING PROFESSOR	Oct.2023 - Present

Professional Experience

For a full list, and a description of responsibilities, please check my [academic CV](#).

ONG RedPapaz

EXTERNAL SCIENTIFIC CONSULTANT

Bogotá, Colombia

Sep. - Oct. 2022

Protect Children

INTERNATIONAL SCIENTIFIC CONSULTANT

Helsinki, Finlandia

Jul. - Aug. 2021

Grants

Social Sciences and Humanities Research Council

PARTNERSHIP ENGAGE GRANTS, 2024

Halifax, Canada

Dic. 2024 - Dic. 2025

- Project: A Partnership for the Prevention of Sexual Exploitation of Children in Travel and Tourism in Colombia
- Role: Co-researcher
- CAD\$25.000

Universidad El Bosque

IX INTERNAL CALL FOR FINANCING RESEARCH AND TECHNOLOGICAL INNOVATION PROJECTS EL BOSQUE UNIVERSITY, 2024

Bogota, Colombia

Jan. 2024 - Jan. 2026

- Project: Effect of real and simulated resource control on androphilic women's preferences for masculinity in men's faces: an experimental study using eye-tracking
- Role: Principal Researcher
- COP\$90.000.000

Minciencias

POSTDOCTORAL RESEARCH STAYS - CALL 935-2023 - ORCHIDS PROGRAM. WOMEN IN SCIENCE: AGENTS FOR PEACE: AGENTS

Barranquilla, Colombia

Dic. 2023 - Jan. 2025

FOR PEACE 2023

- Project: Effect of resource availability on women's preferences for masculinity faces in interaction with hormonal, cognitive, and socio-contextual factors such as actual resource scarcity and exposure to violence: an experimental study using eye-tracking
- COP\$356.040.884

Minciencias

CALL FOR POSTDOCTORAL FELLOWSHIP PROGRAM IN SNCTEI ENTITIES 2019

Barranquilla, Colombia

Jan. 2021 - Jan. 2022

- Project: Feasibility of new interventions to improve the implementation of sexual and reproductive health programs in Colombia.
- COP\$192.000.000

Minciencias

CALL FOR THE STRENGTHENING OF PROJECTS IN EXECUTION OF CTEI IN HEALTH SCIENCES WITH YOUNG TALENT AND REGIONAL

Bogota, Colombia

Jan. 2021 - Jan. 2022

IMPACT 2020

- Project: Attentional biases and their relationship with heart rate variability as predictors of emotional state in people without affective disorders in the city of Bogotá.
- Role: Principal Researcher
- COP\$76.000.000

Universidad El Bosque

IX INTERNAL CALL FOR FINANCING RESEARCH AND TECHNOLOGICAL INNOVATION PROJECTS EL BOSQUE UNIVERSITY, 2017

Bogota, Colombia

Jan. 2018 - Dic. 2021

- Project: Perceivable signs of physical and mental health in faces, voices and body odors, and their relationship to hormone levels
- Role: Co-researcher
- COP\$136.586.537

Universidad El Bosque

VII INTERNAL CALL FOR FINANCING RESEARCH AND TECHNOLOGICAL INNOVATION PROJECTS EL BOSQUE UNIVERSITY, 2015

Bogota, Colombia

Jan. 2016 - Dic. 2019

- Project: Differences in the pattern of eye tracking to sexually preferred stimuli in men convicted of sexual offenses and the general population
- Role: Principal Researcher
- COP\$80.000.000

Universidad San Buenaventura de Medellín

CONVOCATORIA INTERNA DE INVESTIGACIÓN FINANCIERA DE LA UNIVERSIDAD DE SAN BUENAVENTURA, 2014

Medellín, Colombia

Jun.2014 - Jun.2015

- Project: Mediating factors of Cognitive Reserve and its relationship with the neuropsychological profile of the older adult in the process of normal aging
- Role: Principal Researcher
- COP\$20.000.000

Scholarships, Awards and Honors

Universidad El Bosque

X EXCELLENCE AWARDS

- COP\$10.000.000

Bogotá, Colombia

Dic. 2023

Universidad El Bosque

VIII EXCELLENCE AWARDS

- COP\$5.000.000

Bogotá, Colombia

Dic. 2019

Universidad El Bosque

VII EXCELLENCE AWARDS

- COP\$2.500.000

Bogotá, Colombia

Dic. 2018

Universidad de Valencia

CUM LAUDE MENTION

- PhD Thesis in Neurosciences

Valencia, España

Sep. 2018

Universidad de Valencia

LUISA CARDONA SCHOLARSHIP

- Fee exemption for the Official Master's Degree

Valencia, España

Nov.2011 - Nov.2012

Universidad Católica de Colombia

HONORARY DEGREE

- Improved performance among undergraduate psychology students

Bogotá, Colombia

Sep. 2007

Universidad Católica de Colombia

MENTION FOR EXCELLENCE

- Mention postgraduate scholarship for obtaining the highest score among the psychology students of the faculty and 3rd place nationally in the 2006 version of the Quality Examination for Higher Education in Colombia (ECAES).

Bogotá, Colombia

Mar.2007

Selected Publications

6 *h*-index 19 *g*-index 5 *i10*-index 26 Publications 396 Citations

For a full list, please check the publications section on my [academic CV](#).

Vásquez-Amézquita, M., Castellanos-Chacón, A., Medina-Sarmiento, W., Cepeda, V., Martínez-González, M. B., & Leongómez, J. D. (2025). Resource availability and experiences of partner violence shape facial masculinity preferences in Colombian women. *Evolution and Human Behavior*, 46(4), 106707. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.evolhumbehav.2025.106707>

Vásquez-Amézquita, M., Cepeda, V., Roa, E., Torres, J. S., Maldonado-Avenidaño, N., Martínez-González, M. B., & Leongómez, J. D. (2025). Sexual modes questionnaire (SMQ): Spanish translation, adaptation, and preliminary evidence of psychometric properties in a Colombian sample. *Sexual and Relationship Therapy*, 1–25. <https://doi.org/10.1080/14681994.2025.2507109>

Vásquez-Amézquita, M., Leongómez, J. D., Salvador, A., & Seto, M. C. (2023). What can the eyes tell us about atypical sexual preferences as a function of sex and age? Linking eye movements with child-related chronophiliacs. *Forensic Sciences Research*, 8(1)1–11. <https://doi.org/10.1093/fsr/owad009>

Vásquez-Amézquita, M., Salvador, A., & Leongómez, J. D. (2021). Existen diferencias en la ratio 2D:4D entre delincuentes sexuales y no sexuales, y hombres no delincuentes? Un estudio en una muestra colombiana. *Interdisciplinaria. Revista de Psicología y Ciencias Afines*, 39(1). <https://doi.org/10.16888/interd.2022.39.1.8>

Jones, B. C., DeBruine, L. M., Flake, J. K., Liuzza, M. T., Antfolk, J., Arinze, N. C., Ndukaihe, I. L. G., Bloxson, N. G., Lewis, S. C., Foroni, F., Willis, M. L., Cubillas, C. P., Vadiello, M. A., Turiegano, E., Gilead, M., Simchon, A., Saribay, S. A., Owsley, N. C., Jang, C. ..., **Vásquez-Amézquita, M.**, ..., Coles, N. A. (2021). To which world regions does the valence–dominance model of social perception apply? *Nature Human Behaviour*, 5(1) 159–169. <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41562-020-01007-2>

Vásquez-Amézquita, M., Leongómez, J. D., Seto, M. C., Bonilla, F. M., Rodríguez-Padilla, A., & Salvador, A. (2018). No relation between digit ratio (2D:4D) and visual attention patterns to sexually preferred and non-preferred stimuli. *Personality and Individual Differences*, 120, 151–158. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.paid.2017.08.022>

Vásquez-Amézquita, M., Leongómez, J. D., Seto, M. C., Bonilla, M., Rodríguez-Padilla, A., & Salvador, A. (2019). Visual Attention Patterns Differ in Gynephilic and Androphilic Men and Women Depending on Age and Gender of Targets. *The Journal of Sex Research*, 56(1), 85–101. <https://doi.org/10.1080/00224499.2017.1372353>

Vásquez-Amézquita, M., Leongómez, J. D., Seto, M. C., & Salvador, A. (2019). Differences in Visual Attention Patterns to Sexually Mature and Immature Stimuli Between Heterosexual Sexual Offenders, Nonsexual Offenders, and Nonoffending Men. *The Journal of Sex Research*, 56 (2), 213–228. <https://doi.org/10.1080/00224499.2018.1511965>

Postgraduate Supervision

For a full list, including undergraduate supervision, please check my [academic CV](#).

Leidy Nathaly Peláez Bernal

MSC IN NEUROPSYCHOLOGY

*Universidad Internacional de
Valencia, España
2023-2024*

Jimena Zanizo Chambi

MSC IN NEUROPSYCHOLOGY

*Universidad Internacional de
Valencia, España
2023-2024*

Liceth Andrea Zaraza Osorio

MSC IN NEUROPSYCHOLOGY

*Universidad Internacional de
Valencia, España
2023-2024*